Hell – Is God a Sadist?

***Purpose**: To show that the purpose of Hell is to destroy sin forever.*

***Centred on**: God's righteousness.*

How do you see God?...1 Jn 4:8 God is Love (must remain on the table)

Introduction:

The concept of an eternal hell is closely linked to the concept of the eternal soul lie given by Satan in Eden (Gen 3:4)"you will not surely die"! This spread throughout the Pagan churches and remained when apostacy entered the Apostolic Church. (Translations of Hell – "Sheol & Hades"h7585,g0086 = Grave; "Gehenna"g1067 (Matt5:22-valley of Hinnon, Rubbish dump) = fires of destruction; "Tartarus"g5020 = place of darkness)

Ezekiel 33: 11…God has no pleasure in the death of the wicked! Gods asks why should you die when I have paid the price on your behalf. (Hosea 4:6…my people are destroyed for lack of knowledge) <u>If Atheist knew the truth about God they wouldn't be Atheist's!</u>

<u>Where is Hell?</u>

Revelation 20: 9-15…Fire came down from God and devoured them. *Hell is on the breadth of the earth*. Tormented forever and ever. Two views – Destroyed or Tormented Forever.

Let us see from scripture that God isn't a sadist and will not torment forever….

Jude 7…Here we find an **example** of the vengeance of **"eternal fire."** Today, Sodom and Gomorrah aren't burning and are in fact uninhabited to this day (today, this area of land lay at the bottom of the Dead Sea). So the *effects* are eternal, not the *duration*.

Malachi 4: 1-3…Some key points here: (similar to what we read in Rev 20)

- Day is coming (future).
- They shall be Chaff **(ashes)**.
- Burn them up.
- Will leave neither root nor branch.

Psalm 37:9-11,20…The wicked will be no more, vanish, smoke. V11… You can look and you will not find them. (also Obadiah 1:15,16) But remember God wants us all to be saved!

John 3:16,17…God gives believers eternal life as he doesn't want us to perish.

Romans 6:23…Sin = Death but God gives life.

Is anyone in Hell today?

Matt 13:40-42… "at the end", also John 12:48 Judged at the last day…also Jn 5:28,29 says the wicked are called from the Graves not from hellfire. What kind of God would inflict 6,000 years more punishment on someone like Cain killing one man than Hitler for millions. (2 Pet 3:3-14)

What Part of a person enters Hell?

Matthew 5:30…not just for a mystical soul…also Matt 10:28..both soul and body in hell. (life & Body)

How long does Hell burn for?

The memory of it on the minds of the living forever

Revelation 14: 9-11… ***"The smoke of their torment ascends forever and ever."*** This passage is often used to support the doctrine of eternal torment. It must be understood that the book of Revelation is a collection of Old Testament ideas/imagery. In this verse (11), John uses a language that is almost verbatim to *what Isaiah wrote(next txt)*… Note verse 10, "…full strength into the *cup* of his indignation." So in Matthew 26, Jesus was about to drink the cup of revelation 14. This is why he nearly came to a point of death and required heavenly assistance (Luke 22: 43).
Important point: Just before the Gethsemane experience was the Lords supper. Here Jesus offered *His cup of righteousness* in exchange for *our cup of unrighteousness*. (Matthew 26: 27).

The whole point is that we don't have to experience the second death!

Isaiah 34: 8-10…Many times the Old Testament writers when writing about particular nations (Edom v5) or groups of people, they are in fact a "type" of a future fulfilment. Notice the use of the same term "Its smoke shall ascend forever." Isaiah further elaborates on this meaning…"from generation to generation, it shall lie waste. Moreover, "no one shall pass through it forever and ever."

Maybe John in Revelation is pointing us back to Isaiah as an example of his vision of the destruction at the last day. Let's now look at an example of forever

Jonah 2:6, 10…Was Jonah in the Belly forever? 1:17(Ex 21:6-serve forever; 1 Sam 1:22, 28)

> "I went down to the moorings of the mountains; The earth with its bars closed behind me forever; Yet You have brought up my life from the pit, O Lord, my God. 10. So the Lord spoke to the fish, and it vomited Jonah onto dry land."

Lets look at the Fire

Jeremiah 17:27…Jerusalem was burned by the Babylonians. Also by the Romans. Is it still burning? Unquenchable fire destroyed Jerusalem and it will destroy the wicked.

Hebrews 12: 29… **"Our God is a consuming Fire."** Can this teach us something about Hell? Sin and God can't co-exist together. Q. What is this Fire!

Exodus 24:17… The sight of God's glory is a consuming fire. If God is life who is a consuming fire then the living will dwell with a consuming fire. Remember Moses a sinful being couldn't look at God's glory on Mt Sinai, for it would consume him. (Ex 19:21 warning to the people; Ex 33:18-23) (Rev 15:2 – Sea of glass - mingled with Fire)

Isaiah 33: 14-15…Only the righteous are able to dwell with the consuming fire! The wicked are consumed! It is amazing how popular teachings have switched things around.

> *God is Eternal, so is his glory which is a consuming fire. Eternal Glory, Eternal Fire. The fire that destroyed in the past is still burning now but that which was consumed by it, is not.*

The major doctrine teaches that the wicked are going to be dwelling with an everlasting fire, and yet we find scripture teaching us that the righteous will take this place. Let's look at what Jesus says …

Matthew 25: 41…According to this text, who was the everlasting fire prepared for?

If Hell was prepared for the Devil and his angels, what then was prepared for us?

God cannot grant life to anybody who rejects Him for He is life. There is no such thing as life outside of God. The Devil and his angels are determined to reject God and therefore determined to reject life. God simply gives them what they have chosen.

John 14:1-3…What is God preparing for us? A place because God wants us to be **with** him. There will be no other people except those with God.

Revelation 20:9…(1 John 4:8) Replace the word God with Love in verse 20:9. Then God will create a new Heaven and a New Earth (Rev 21:1)

Three points to know about the Good news regarding Hell:

- Hell fire will completely destroy the Wicked at the end of this world.
- You don't have to be there. God wants us all to be in Heaven. Freechoice
- Christ would rather go to Hell for you,(Separate from God.) than live in heaven without you.

APPEALS:

- God is not a sadist. He is just and honors our choices. He has proven in Christ that He would rather not exist without us.
- Mt. 27:36-42 / Mt. 10:28 (Jesus experiencing hell)

- Christ separated from His Father in order to save us.
- Christ offers his cup of mercy then goes to the garden and drinks the cup of wrath.
- We need not drink the cup of wrath. Christ already drank it for us.

Difficult texts:

People in the name of God make him look like a demon

The Rich Man and Lazarus:

Luke 16: 19-31… *(Is this to be regarded as literal)?*

Problems with this text:

- Dip the tip of his finger in water to cool my tongue (verse 24).
- Carried by angels to Abraham's bosom (verse 23).
- Abraham not having the promises (Hebrews 11: 10; 13).

To understand this dialogue, we must first understand who the target audience is. Initially Jesus is speaking to his disciples and without a doubt a large audience was also present (Luke 16: 1). However, in verse 9, Jesus has turned his focus from the disciples to the Pharisees present.

Now it was common knowledge that the Pharisees were lovers of money (Luke 16: 14), in fact it was regarded by them as evidence of Gods favour and that poverty was deemed as a curse from God. The Pharisees also prided themselves as being related to Abraham and therefore being saved by virtue of inheritance (John 8: 39).

Now, in the story of the rich man and Lazarus, Lazarus was Poor. So in the eyes of the Pharisees, he must have been cursed of God. Then we have the rich man who was obviously in favour with God, but in this parable we find a direct reversal of the Parasitic assumptions as the one that was expected to go to heaven ends up in Hell (verse23), and the poor one ends up in Abrahams bosom (verse 22). The reason why Jesus used Abraham's bosom was due to the Pharisees claim to be the sons of Abraham. Notice in verse 24, the rich man is calling to Abraham.

- Rich man represents the Pharisees (Israel).

Matthew 15: 21-28…Here Jesus seems to be acting kind of heartless? But he was actually teaching a lesson to the disciples. This woman was a Pagan/Gentile; now note her statement in verse 27, *"Yet even the little dogs eat the crumbs which fall from the masters table."*

Luke 16: 20-21… *"Desiring to be fed with the crumbs which fell from the masters table."*

- Lazarus represents the gentiles.

Basically what we have here is the rich man representing Israel and the beggar representing Gentiles. Israel is rich in that they had Gods word! Which they were supposed to share with the world but they became proud and greedy. All the while, the gentiles were starving and wanted the crumbs from the table of the Jews.

Forever and ever? (Does this mean eternity)?

1 Samuel 1: 22… Here we have Hannah who is very excited that she has a child. She acknowledges that this is an act of God and therefore offers her child to God as a servant within the sanctuary service. Notice when Elkanah and his entire household went to the sanctuary to make an offering, Hannah makes the statement: *"Not until the child is weaned; then I will take him that he may appear before the Lord and remain there FOREVER."*

1 Samuel 1: 28… **Question:** According to this verse, how long did Hannah stipulate the child would remain in the service of the sanctuary?

Answer: *"As long as he lives."* (verse 28).

Jonah 2: 6… Here Jonah was swallowed by a great fish and Jonah is describing his experience in a number of was, but notice how he uses the term "forever."

Jonah 1: 17… **Question:** According to this verse, how long was Jonah caught in the belly of the fish?

Answer: Three days and three nights.

Exodus 21: 6… I think we get the point!

What about the Worm?

Isaiah 66: 24… For their worm does not die?

Psalm 22: 1-2; 6… This is a prophecy of the crucifixion of Jesus. Notice In verse 6, Jesus is referred to as a worm? (A reproach of men).

Isaiah 66: 24… "Upon the corpse of men," (dead men). They shall be abhorrence (a reproach) to all flesh. This is saying the *reproach*/legacy of that person shall not die. Psalm 22 suggests Jesus as claiming to be "a worm." People were looking on him with abhorrence. The saved are not regarded as worms because **Jesus became our worm**.

Is there spirits in Hell?

1 Peter 3:18-20… The Holy Spirit preached to those who were bound up in prison to sin in the days of Noah and now by Jesus resurrection we know that God is trying everything to save us. (Luke 4:18; Psalm 142:7) Gen 6:3…My Spirit will not always strive. 2 Peter 2:4,5…

"A Great Gulf Fixed"

In the parable of the rich man and Lazarus, Christ shows that in this life men decide their eternal destiny. During probationary time the grace of God is offered to every soul. But if men waste their opportunities in self-pleasing, they cut themselves off from everlasting life. No after- probation will be granted them. By their own choice they have fixed an impassable gulf between them and their God.

This parable draws a contrast between the rich who have not made God their dependence, and the poor who have made God their dependence. Christ shows that the time is coming when the position of the two classes will be reversed. Those who are poor in this world's goods, yet who trust in God and are patient in suffering will one day be exalted above those who now hold the highest positions the world can give but who have not surrendered their life to God.

"There was a certain rich man," Christ said, "which was clothed in purple and fine linen, and fared sumptuously every day. And there was a certain beggar named Lazarus, which was laid at his gate, full of sores, and desiring to be fed with the crumbs which fell from the rich man's table."

The rich man did not belong to the class represented by the unjust judge, who openly declared his disregard for God and man. He claimed to be a son of Abraham. He did not treat the beggar with violence or require him to go away because the sight of him was disagreeable. If the poor, loathsome specimen of humanity could be comforted by beholding him as he entered his gates, the rich man was willing that he should remain. But he was selfishly indifferent to the needs of his suffering brother.

There were then no hospitals in which the sick might be cared for. The suffering and needy were brought to the notice of those to whom the Lord had entrusted wealth, that they might receive help and sympathy. Thus it was with the beggar and the rich man. Lazarus was in great need of help; for he was without friends, home, money, or food. Yet he was allowed to remain in this condition day after day, while the wealthy nobleman had every want supplied. The one who was abundantly able to relieve the sufferings of his fellow creature, lived to himself, as many live today.

There are today close beside us many who are hungry, naked, and homeless. A neglect to impart of our means to these needy, suffering ones places upon us a burden of guilt which we shall one day fear to meet. All covetousness is condemned as idolatry. All selfish indulgence is an offense in God's sight.

God had made the rich man a steward of His means, and it was his duty to attend to just such cases as that of the beggar. The command had been given, *"Thou shalt love the Lord thy God with all thine heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy might"* (Deut. 6:5); and *"thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself" (*Lev. 19:18).

The rich man was a Jew, and he was acquainted with the command of God. But he forgot that he was accountable for the use of his entrusted means and capabilities. The Lord's blessings rested upon him abundantly, but he employed them selfishly, to honour himself, not his Maker. In

proportion to his abundance was his obligation to use his gifts for the uplifting of humanity. This was the Lord's command, but the rich man had no thought of his obligation to God.

He lent money, and took interest for what he loaned; but he returned no interest for what God had lent him. He had knowledge and talents, but did not improve them. Forgetful of his accountability to God, he devoted all his powers to pleasure. Everything with which he was surrounded, his round of amusements, the praise and flattery of his friends, ministered to his selfish enjoyment. So engrossed was he in the society of his friends that he lost all sense of his responsibility to co-operate with God in His ministry of mercy. He had opportunity to understand the word of God and to practice its teachings; but the pleasure-loving society he chose so occupied his time that he forgot the God of eternity.

The time came when a change took place in the condition of the two men. The poor man had suffered day by day, but he had patiently and quietly endured. In the course of time he died and was buried. There was no one to mourn for him; but by his patience in suffering he had witnessed for Christ, he had endured the test of his faith, and at his death he is represented as being carried by the angels into Abraham's bosom.

Lazarus represents the suffering poor who believe in Christ. When the trumpet sounds and all that are in the graves hear Christ's voice and come forth, they will receive their reward; for their faith in God was not a mere theory, but a reality.

"The rich man also died, and was buried; and in hell he lifts up his eyes, being in torments, and sees Abraham afar off and Lazarus in his bosom. And he cried and said, Father Abraham, have mercy on me, and send Lazarus that he may dip the tip of his finger in water, and cool my tongue; for I am tormented in this flame."

In this parable Christ was meeting the people on their own ground. The doctrine of a conscious state of existence between death and the resurrection was held by many of those who were listening to Christ's words. The Saviour knew of their ideas, and He framed His parable so as to inculcate important truths through these preconceived opinions. He held up before His hearers a mirror wherein they might see themselves in their true relation to God. He used the prevailing opinion to convey the idea He wished to make prominent to all--that no man is valued for his possessions; for all he has belongs to him only as lent by the Lord. A misuse of these gifts will place him below the poorest and most afflicted man who loves God and trusts in Him.

Christ desires His hearers to understand that it is impossible for men to secure the salvation of the soul after death. Abraham is represented as answering:

"Son, remember that in your lifetime you received your good things, and likewise Lazarus evil things; but now he is comforted, and you are tormented. And beside all this, between us and you there is a great gulf fixed; so that those who want to pass from here to you cannot; nor can those from there pass to us."

Thus Christ represented the hopelessness of looking for a second probation. This life is the only time given to man in which to prepare for eternity. The rich man had not abandoned the idea that he was a child of Abraham, and in his distress he is represented as calling upon him for aid. "*Father Abraham*," he prayed, "*have mercy on me.*" He did not pray to God, but to Abraham. Thus he

showed that he placed Abraham above God, and that he relied on his relationship to Abraham for salvation.

The thief on the cross offered his prayer to Christ. *"Remember me when you come into your kingdom,"* he said. (Luke 23:42.) And at once the response came, *"assuredly, I say to you today* (as I hang on the cross in humiliation and suffering), *you will be with me in Paradise."* But the rich man prayed to Abraham, and his petition was not granted. Christ alone is exalted to be "a Prince and a Saviour, for to give repentance to Israel, and forgiveness of sins." (Acts 5:31). "Neither is there salvation in any other." (Acts 4:12).

The rich man had spent his life in self-pleasing, and too late he saw that he had made no provision for eternity. He realized his folly, and thought of his brothers, who would go on as he had gone, living to please themselves. Then he made the request, "I beg you therefore, father, that you would send him [Lazarus] to my father's house; for I have five brothers that he may testify to them, lest they also come to this place of torment." But "Abraham said to him, they have Moses and the prophets; let them hear them. And he said, No, father Abraham; but if one goes to them from the dead, they will repent. But he said to him, if they do not hear Moses and the prophets, neither will they be persuaded though one rose from the dead."

When the rich man solicited additional evidence for his brothers, he was plainly told that should this evidence be given, they would not be persuaded. His request cast a reflection on God. It was as if the rich man had said, if you had more thoroughly warned me, I should not now be here. Abraham in his answer to this request is represented as saying; your brothers have been sufficiently warned. Light has been given them, but they would not see; truth has been presented to them, but they would not hear.

"If they hear not Moses and the prophets, neither will they be persuaded, though one rose from the dead." These words were proved true in the history of the Jewish nation. Christ's last and crowning miracle was the raising of Lazarus of Bethany, after he had been dead four days. The Jews were given this wonderful evidence of the Saviour's divinity, but they rejected it. Lazarus rose from the dead and bore his testimony before them, but they hardened their hearts against all evidence, and even sought to take his life. (John 12:9-11.)

The law and the prophets are God's appointed agencies for the salvation of men. Christ said; Let them give heed to these evidences. If they do not listen to the voice of God in His word, the testimony of a witness raised from the dead would not be heeded.

Those who heed Moses and the prophets will require no greater light than God has given; but if men reject the light, and fail to appreciate the opportunities granted them, they would not hear if one from the dead should come to them with a message. They would not be convinced even by this evidence; for those who reject the law and the prophets so harden their hearts that they will reject all light. The conversation between Abraham and the once-rich man is figurative. The lesson to be gathered from it is that every man is given sufficient light for the discharge of the duties required of him. Man's responsibilities are proportionate to his opportunities and privileges. God gives to everyone sufficient light and grace to do the work He has given him to do.

If man fails to do that which a little light shows to be his duty, greater light would only reveal unfaithfulness, neglect to improve the blessings given. *"He that is faithful in that which is least is faithful also in much; and he that is unjust in the least is unjust also in much."* (Luke 16:10).

Those who refuse to be enlightened by Moses and the prophets and ask for some wonderful miracle to be performed would not be convinced if their wish were granted.

The parable of the rich man and Lazarus shows how the two classes represented by these men are estimated in the unseen world. There is no sin in being rich if riches are not acquired by injustice. A rich man is not condemned for having riches, but condemnation rests upon him if the means entrusted to him is spent in selfishness. Far better might he lay up his money beside the throne of God, by using it to do good. Death cannot make any man poor who thus devotes himself to seeking eternal riches. But the man who hoards his treasure for self cannot take any of it to heaven. He has proved himself to be an unfaithful steward. During his lifetime he had his good things, but he was forgetful of his obligation to God. He failed of securing the heavenly treasure.

The rich man who had so many privileges is represented to us as one who should have cultivated his gifts, so that his works should reach to the great beyond, carrying with them improved spiritual advantages. It is the purpose of redemption, not only to blot out sin, but to give back to man those spiritual gifts lost because of sin's dwarfing power. Money cannot be carried into the next life; it is not needed there; but the good deeds done in winning souls to Christ are carried to the heavenly courts. But those who selfishly spend the Lord's gifts on themselves, leaving their needy fellow creatures without aid and doing nothing to advance God's work in the world, dishonour their Maker. Robbery of God is written opposite their names in the books of heaven.

The rich man had all that money could procure, but he did not possess the riches that would have kept his account right with God. He had lived as if all that he possessed were his own. He had neglected the call of God and the claims of the suffering poor. But at length there comes a call which he cannot neglect. By a power which he cannot question or resist he is commanded to quit the premises of which he is no longer steward. The once-rich man is reduced to hopeless poverty. The robe of Christ's righteousness, woven in the loom of heaven, can never cover him. He who once wore the richest purple, the finest linen, is reduced to nakedness. His probation is ended. He brought nothing into the world, and he can take nothing out of it.

Christ lifted the curtain and presented this picture before priests and rulers, scribes and Pharisees. Look at it, you who are rich in this world's goods and are not rich toward God. Will you not contemplate this scene? That which is highly esteemed among men is abhorrent in the sight of God. Christ asks, *"What shall it profit a man, if he shall gain the whole world, and lose his own soul? Or what shall a man give in exchange for his soul?"* (Mark 8:36, 37).

White, Ellen Gould: Christ's Object Lessons. Review and Herald Publishing Association, 1900; 2002, S. 260